

FL.3 Inspection Sequence

The document that has to be recorded before anyone will inspect you, the inspections themselves, and a log.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. Florida is the opposite of a no-permit state: one building code binds every parcel in all 67 counties, every jurisdiction permits and inspects, and a local government may not simply write its own residential code. What still varies is the part that costs you money and weeks — fees, impact fees, review queues, portals, and which *additional* permits your particular lot triggers before the building department will act. Confirm every item with the office that will actually handle your parcel before you rely on it.

THE DOCUMENT THAT GATES YOUR FIRST INSPECTION

Florida's **Notice of Commencement** is the single most common way an owner-builder's job stops dead in its second month. It is not a building department form. You record it with the **clerk of the circuit court** in the county where the property sits, and then you give a copy to the building department.

Get the sequence wrong and the consequence is immediate: “In the absence of the filing of a copy of the notice of commencement, the issuing authority or a private provider performing inspection services **may not perform or approve subsequent inspections** until the applicant files... such copy with the issuing authority” (s. 713.135(1)(e)1., Fla. Stat.).

Notice of Commencement — the six things to get right

	The rule	Cite
Record it before you start work	The owner, “before actually commencing to improve any real property,... shall record a notice of commencement.” Recording is a precondition of starting, not of permitting.	713.13(1)(a)
But not too early	“If the improvement described in the notice of commencement is not actually commenced within 90 days after the recording thereof, such notice is void and of no further effect.” Record it, then start.	713.13(2)
Post a copy at the site	Post either a certified copy or a notarized statement that it has been filed for recording, along with a copy. This is a standing obligation, not a one-time act.	713.13(1)(a)
File a copy with the building department	Required before the first inspection where the direct contract is greater than \$5,000 — which a house always is.	713.135(1)(e)

Notice of Commencement — the six things to get right

	The rule	Cite
You sign it, personally	“The owner must sign the notice of commencement and no one else may be permitted to sign in his or her stead.” It is sworn — the statutory form carries a notary block, and Florida allows online notarization.	713.13(1)(g), (1)(d)
It expires in a year	Effective for 1 year from recording unless the notice states a longer period. If your build will run longer, say so in the notice or amend it before it lapses.	713.13(6), (5)(a)

Sections 713.13 and 713.135, Fla. Stat. (2026). The recording threshold itself sits elsewhere: an improvement with a direct contract price of \$2,500 or less is exempt (s. 713.02(5)), and s. 713.135(1) does not apply to a contract to repair or replace an existing heating or air-conditioning system under \$15,000.

Why letting it lapse costs money, not just time

The statutory form carries this warning in capitals, and it is the whole point of the document: “ANY PAYMENTS MADE BY THE OWNER AFTER THE EXPIRATION OF THE NOTICE OF COMMENCEMENT ARE CONSIDERED IMPROPER PAYMENTS UNDER CHAPTER 713... AND CAN RESULT IN YOUR PAYING TWICE FOR IMPROVEMENTS TO YOUR PROPERTY.”

Owner-builder jobs run long. A notice recorded at the footing on a build that takes fifteen months expires with the trim still going in — and every payment you make after that date loses its protection. **Put the expiry date in your calendar the day you record it**, and amend the notice to extend the period before it runs out. An amendment may extend the effective period, but changing contractors requires a new notice.

One thing the building department may **not** do: require the notice as a condition of issuing your permit. The statute says so expressly (s. 713.135(1)(f), (1)(e)4.). The permit can issue first; the notice gates the inspections.

THE GATE BEFORE THE PERMIT, AND THE GATE BEFORE YOU MOVE IN

If your lot is on septic, one statute governs both ends of your project, and it is not in the building code. Section 381.0065(4), Fla. Stat. provides that a local government

Section 381.0065(4), Fla. Stat.

“...may not issue a building or plumbing permit for any building that requires the use of an onsite sewage treatment and disposal system **unless the owner or builder has received a construction permit for such system from the department**. A building or structure may not be occupied and a municipality, political subdivision, or any state or federal agency may not authorize occupancy **until the department approves the final installation** of the onsite sewage treatment and disposal system.”

Read that twice if you are on septic. Your septic **construction permit** is a prerequisite to your **building permit** — so the septic application is the first thing you file, not something you get to later. And the septic **final installation approval** is a prerequisite to occupancy, independent of your certificate of occupancy. Two separate approvals from an agency that is not your building department. FL.4 explains which agency that is in your county, because in 2026 the answer is genuinely split.

THE REQUIRED INSPECTIONS

Unlike most states in this series, Florida's inspection list is **codified statewide** in the building code rather than left to local option. FBC Building 110.3 sets the minimum for a one- or two-family dwelling. Your building department will add trade inspections and may add more; it may not require fewer.

FBC Building 110.3 — statewide minimum inspections

	Inspection	What it covers
1	Foundation	After trenches are excavated and forms erected. Covers stem-wall, monolithic slab-on-grade, piling and pile caps, footers and grade beams. In a flood hazard area the elevation certification must be submitted upon placement of the lowest floor, before any further vertical construction.
2	Underground trades	Plumbing and electrical below slab, before cover. Your building department schedules these against the trade permits rather than the 110.3 list.
3	Sheathing	Roof and wall sheathing, sheathing fasteners , and roof and wall dry-in. This is the nailing inspection — in a hurricane state it is the one inspectors fail people on, and it can be taken as part of dry-in or separately.
4	Framing	Window and door framing, vertical cells and columns, lintels and tie beams, trusses, bracing and connectors, draft stopping and fire blocking, energy insulation, and a rough-opening dimension tolerance check.
5	Rough trade inspections	Electrical, plumbing and mechanical rough-in before cover, under their own permits.

FBC Building 110.3 — statewide minimum inspections

	Inspection	What it covers
6	Roofing	Dry-in, insulation, roof coverings and flashing.
7	Exterior wall coverings	Wall coverings and veneers, and soffit coverings.
8	Impact-resistant coverings and systems	Where shutters or impact glazing are installed, the building official schedules inspections to confirm the system on the plans was actually installed, and installed per the manufacturer's instructions and the product approval . This is where your FL numbers get checked against reality.
9	Final	Building complete and ready for occupancy, plus final trade inspections. In a flood hazard area a final certification of the lowest floor elevation must be submitted as part of the final inspection — a second elevation document, not the same one you filed at the foundation.

FBC Building 110.3, 8th Edition (2023). Threshold-building special inspections do not reach a house: a “threshold building” is one greater than three stories or 50 feet, or an assembly occupancy over 5,000 square feet with more than 500 occupants (s. 553.71(12), Fla. Stat.).

One approved inspection every 180 days keeps the permit alive

A permit becomes invalid if work is not commenced within 6 months, or if work is suspended or abandoned for 6 months. The definition that saves a slow owner-builder build is this one: “Work shall be considered to be in active progress when the permit has received an **approved inspection within 180 days**.” (FBC Building 105.4.1, 105.4.1.3.) If you are going to be away from the job for a season, schedule an inspection you can pass before you go.

THE THREE THINGS THAT ARRIVE FROM SOMEBODY ELSE

Three sign-offs at the end of a Florida build are produced by people who do not work for the building department, and each has its own lead time. Line them up early.

- **The termite Certificate of Compliance.** A licensed pest control company must issue a certificate to the building department stating that “The building has received a complete treatment for the prevention of subterranean termites.” If you use soil treatment, the initial application inside the foundation perimeter happens *after* excavation, backfill and compaction — and any soil disturbed after treatment has to be retreated. (FBC Residential R318.1.)
- **The blower door test.** Mandatory before your certificate of occupancy, to a maximum of **7 air changes per hour at 50 pascals**, run after every penetration of the thermal envelope is sealed. You may not perform or self-certify it — it takes an energy auditor or rater, a Class A or B air-conditioning or mechanical contractor, or a third party approved by the code official. Below 3 ACH50 the code then requires whole-house mechanical ventilation. (FBC Energy Conservation R402.4.1.2.)

- **Septic final installation approval.** Occupancy may not be authorized until the department approves the final installation (s. 381.0065(4), Fla. Stat.). This is separate from your building final, and it comes from a different office.

INSPECTION LOG

Record every inspection as it happens

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Notice of Commencement recorded Book/Page: _____ Expires: _____		
☐	Copy of NOC filed with building department Filed: _____		
☐	Septic construction permit in hand (before building permit) Permit no.: _____		
☐	Foundation Inspector: _____ Result: _____		
☐	Elevation certification at lowest floor (flood hazard area only) Submitted: _____		
☐	Underground plumbing / electrical Inspector: _____ Result: _____		
☐	Sheathing and fasteners / dry-in Inspector: _____ Result: _____		
☐	Framing Inspector: _____ Result: _____		
☐	Electrical rough-in Inspector: _____ Result: _____		
☐	Plumbing rough-in Inspector: _____ Result: _____		
☐	Mechanical rough-in Inspector: _____ Result: _____		

Record every inspection as it happens

	Item	Date	Notes
☐	Roofing Inspector: _____ Result: _____		
☐	Exterior wall coverings Inspector: _____ Result: _____		
☐	Impact-resistant coverings verified against product approval Inspector: _____ Result: _____		
☐	Insulation Inspector: _____ Result: _____		
☐	Termite Certificate of Compliance filed Company: _____ Date: _____		
☐	Blower door test passed ACH50: _____ Tested by: _____		
☐	Septic final installation approval Approved: _____		
☐	Final building inspection Inspector: _____ Result: _____		
☐	Final elevation certification (flood hazard area only) Submitted: _____		
☐	Certificate of occupancy issued Date: _____		

SOURCES

Sources — every Florida claim in this document (verified September 2026)

What this document states	Authority
The owner must record a notice of commencement before commencing to improve the property, and post a certified copy or notarized statement at the site	s. 713.13(1)(a)
A notice is void if the improvement is not commenced within 90 days of recording	s. 713.13(2)
The owner must sign the notice personally; the statutory form is sworn before a notary	s. 713.13(1)(d), (1)(g)
The notice is effective for 1 year from recording unless it states otherwise, and may be amended to extend that period	s. 713.13(6), (5)(a)
Payments made after the notice expires are improper payments and can result in paying twice	s. 713.13(1)(c) and the statutory form
A copy must be filed with the issuing authority before the first inspection where the direct contract exceeds \$5,000, and inspections may not be performed or approved until it is	s. 713.135(1)(e), (1)(e)1.
Recording may not be required as a condition of applying for or issuing a building permit	s. 713.135(1)(e)4., (1)(f)
Improvements with a direct contract price of \$2,500 or less are exempt; s. 713.135(1) does not reach an HVAC repair or replacement contract under \$15,000	ss. 713.02(5), 713.135(1)(f)
No building or plumbing permit may issue without a septic construction permit, and occupancy may not be authorized until final installation is approved	s. 381.0065(4)
The statewide minimum inspection list, the flood elevation certifications at lowest floor and at final, and the impact-resistant covering inspection	FBC Building 110.3
A permit stays in active progress with an approved inspection within 180 days	FBC Building 105.4.1, 105.4.1.3
Threshold buildings are over three stories or 50 feet, so the special inspector regime does not reach a house	s. 553.71(12)
Termite protection and the licensed pest control company's Certificate of Compliance	FBC Residential R318.1
Maximum 7 ACH50, who may perform the test, and mechanical ventilation below 3 ACH50	FBC Energy Conservation R402.4.1.2

Every source cited in this kit is free to read. A **Fla. Stat.** section is at **flsenate.gov** → Laws → Florida Statutes, or go straight to the section by typing the year and number into the address bar — **flsenate.gov/Laws/Statutes/2024/489.103** — which is faster than the search box (chapters used here: **489** contracting, **553** the building code, **713** construction liens, **161** coastal, **373** water). A rule cited as **F.A.C.** is at **flrules.org** → Search → by rule number. The building code itself is at **floridabuilding.org** → Codes, free to read online without an account. **One warning when you check a number:** flsenate.gov keeps every past year's statutes at a nearly identical address, so a search result can hand you a repealed version — check that the year in the URL is the current one before you rely on the text. All text here was read at those sources, September 2026.